under the writ of a so-called "double engine" BJP government—one that controls both the state and the Centre—making its paralysis all the more incomprehensible.

THE BIREN PARADOX

Manipur, like other northeastern states, has been a critical part of the BJP's political strategy in the region. The party has made significant inroads into the area over the past decade, and Biren has been a key architect in this. As former Congress leaders, he and son-in-law and MLA, R.K. Imo Singh, have also brought significant political capital. Removing Biren could destabilise the party from within as the BJP still doesn't have an organisational base in the state.

REMOVING CM BIREN SINGH COULD DESTABILISE THE BJP WITHIN AS THE PARTY STILL DOESN'T HAVE AN ORGANISATIONAL BASE IN THE STATE

Biren is also a Meitei with considerable sway over the community, which in turn controls the Imphal valley. Of the 60 seats in the Manipur assembly, 40 are in the Meitei-concentrated Imphal valley. Imposing President's Rule or replacing Biren with a leader seen as less aligned with Meitei interests could further destabilise the state. Thanks to his earlier outreach initiatives, the chief minister also represents a delicate compromise between some groups, particularly the dominant Meitei and the Naga population. "Do they have a competent leader if we remove Biren?" asks Khuraijam Athouba, spokesperson of the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), a Meitei civil society group.

As for President's Rule, in Manipur's complex sociopolitical environment, this could be seen as an overreach by New Delhi. Moreover, the BJP risks losing face, for such a move would signal an acknowledgment of the failure of governance under the BJP, a narrative the Opposition would undoubtedly seize in the national discourse. Internationally, too, given the proximity of Manipur to sensitive borders with Myanmar and China, instability in the state can have strategic consequences. The Centre is cautious about taking any action that might appear reactive or ill-considered, as this could embolden insurgent groups or create room for external interference.

THE CENTRE WON'T HOLD

In recent weeks, Biren has reportedly expressed a desire to step down, frustrated at being reduced to a scapegoat with no real authority over security operations. Since May 30 last year, Kuldiep Singh, the state's security advisor, has chaired the unified command responsible for security decisions, further distancing the chief minister from critical operations. Shortly after, the Centre appointed Rajiv Singh, an IPS officer from the Tripura cadre, as Manipur's Director General of Police. According to the Biren camp, both officers report directly to Union home minister Amit Shah, bypassing the chief minister altogether. Despite the presence of the army, Manipur Police, and nearly 20,000 personnel from 198 companies of central armed police forces, the violence persists, with little or no accountability.

One of Biren's key demands is for control over the unified command to be transferred to the chief minister's office, a move widely supported by Meitei civil society. "There is a lack of coordination between the Centre and the state," says Athouba. "The Union home ministry is giving one set of instructions, while the state issues another. The CM knows the state intimately, he should head the unified command." This sentiment has even sparked student protests in front of the Secretariat and Raj Bhavan in Imphal, with demonstrators calling for Biren to take charge of the security apparatus.

Adding to the grievances is the strained relationship with the Assam Rifles, a paramilitary force under the Union home ministry tasked with combating insurgency in the region. Meitei groups have long accused the force of favouring the Kuki community, alleging that they have been lenient with the Kuki militants operating under the Suspension of Operation (SoO) pact signed in 2008. In a recent move, two battalions of the Assam Rifles—9 and 22—were reassigned to Jammu and Kashmir, with the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) stepping in to replace



Photographs: ANI, REUTERS

MANIPUR'S FLYI

On Sept. 1, violence erupted in Manipur after a four-month lull, with two people killed in a 'high-tech drone' attack on Koutruk and Kadangband villages in Meitei-majority Imphal West district. Kuki militants were allegedly responsible for it. The next day, a similar attack occurred in neighbouring Senjam Chirang village, injuring three people